

Neshat Shahabi

Professor Sinclair

CTCM 2530

April 6th, 2026

A Good Life and Dogs: An Annotated Bibliography

Merkouri, Aikaterini, et al. "Dogs and the Good Life: A Cross-Sectional Study of the Association Between the Dog–Owner Relationship and Owner Mental Wellbeing." *Frontiers in Psychology*, vol. 13, 2022, <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.903647>.

This research really caught my attention because it directly talks about how dogs contribute to a good life by looking at the relationship between dogs and their owners' mental wellbeing. As a computer science junior, I liked how the researchers used actual psychological scales to measure anxiety, depression, emotional support and companionship in over 1,600 dog owners. What really hit me was how the article explores the unconditional love and non judgmental support that dogs provide. This connects perfectly to my belief that pets can help humans in ways other humans sometimes cannot. The study showed that dogs helped owners through really dark times including suicidal thoughts and self harm just by being there and giving people a reason to keep going. I really connected with one quote from a participant who said their dog taught them "to live in the moment" and brought them "true joy." That simplicity is exactly what makes me want to get a dog. The research also talks honestly about the hard parts like guilt and responsibility which helps me think more realistically about what owning a dog would actually be like. What I found most important is how this article helped me understand Haidt's ideas about love and attachment better. It shows how the

Neshat Shahabi

Professor Sinclair

CTCM 2530

April 6th, 2026

bond with dogs works differently than human relationships because it's based on acceptance without judgment and being there consistently without all the complicated social stuff. For someone like me who really values straightforward and reliable connections, this research confirms why getting a dog could be an important part of building my own good life.

Word count: 265

Payne, Elyssa, et al. "Current Perspectives on Attachment and Bonding in the Dog-Human Dyad." *Psychology Research and Behavior Management*, vol. 8, 2015, pp. 71-79, <https://doi.org/10.2147/PRBM.S74972>.

This article really helped me understand why I think dogs can offer something special that human relationships sometimes cannot. The authors explain that dogs actually form real attachment bonds with humans that are similar to how babies bond with their parents. They use ideas from attachment theory that Haidt talks about too. What I found really valuable as I think about getting a dog someday is learning about this thing called the "secure base effect." Basically just having a dog around helps people feel safer and less stressed even if the dog is not actively doing anything special. This fits perfectly with what I believe about dogs offering mental support "without words." The research shows that dogs look for their

Neshat Shahabi

Professor Sinclair

CTCM 2530

April 6th, 2026

owners when they feel stressed and having their human nearby actually calms dogs down too. So it goes both ways. As someone studying computer science, I liked that this is not just nice sounding ideas. The article talks about actual studies that measured things like cortisol levels to prove there are real physical benefits from the bond between humans and dogs. What connected most with my thinking about a good life is how the article says dogs give “unconditional and nonjudgmental fondness.” They accept their owners completely without all the complicated social judgments that happen in human relationships. I'm not saying human relationships are not important but dogs seem to fill a specific spot for simple and reliable attachment. The article also talks about how positive interactions with dogs help both the person and the dog feel better which made me realize that getting a dog is not just about me getting support. It would be about building a relationship that helps us both. This research made me feel even more sure that adding a dog to my life could be a really important part of creating meaning and feeling emotionally secure.

Word count: 312